THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK TWO: MR. PRESIDENT

Chapter 13 — "Year One"

Sunday, January 18, 2026 – Thursday, January 22, 2026

COLD OPEN — "FIFTY-SEVEN"

INT. WHITE HOUSE — THE RESIDENCE — TREATY ROOM — PREDAWN

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20, 2026 — 5:47 AM EST

SUPER: ONE YEAR AGO TODAY: 12:02 PM, THE CAPITOL ROTUNDA

The room where President McKinley signed the treaty ending the Spanish-American War. Dark green walls. A single brass lamp. Outside the window, the Washington Monument is lit against a black sky, and a thin crust of old snow lies on the South Lawn.

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (34), in gray Howard sweats and reading glasses he refuses to wear in public, sits at the massive Grant cabinet table with a yellow legal pad. One number is written on it, very large, and circled three times:

INSERT — the legal pad: "57"

Under it, in a column, thirteen names of United States Senators. Six have check marks. Four have question marks. Three have been crossed out.

The door opens. ESTHER BULLOCK (33), in a robe, two mugs of coffee. She sets one down in front of him and reads the pad upside down.

ESTHER
It was fifty-seven when I went to bed.

MARC
It was fifty-seven when you went to bed, it was fifty-seven at two, and it's fifty-seven now. It's a very consistent number. I respect it.

ESTHER
You need sixty.

MARC
I need sixty.

ESTHER
And you're not going to do what Grace wants.

MARC
I'm not going to blow up the Senate to pass a bill that's supposed to last a hundred years. If I can't get sixty votes for it, it isn't ready.

Esther sits on the edge of the table, the way she used to sit on the kitchen counter at Sunrise Hill.

ESTHER
Do you know what today is?

MARC
Cloture is Thursday.

ESTHER
Marc.

MARC
(beat; softer)
One year.

ESTHER
One year. A year ago right now you were in the Blair House throwing up.

MARC
I was not throwing up. I was nervous in the bathroom.

ESTHER
For forty minutes.

He laughs. She takes his glasses off, folds them, and puts them in his sweatshirt pocket.

ESTHER
The girls have something for you.

MARC
It's five-fifty in the morning.

ESTHER
They set an alarm. Emma's been working on it since Christmas. Act surprised. Act graded.

The door bursts open. EMMA BULLOCK (13), eighth grade, Sidwell Friends sweatshirt, holding a laminated document in a clear plastic sleeve. Behind her, VICTORIA BULLOCK (13), still in pajamas, holding a bowling ball for reasons nobody asks about.

EMMA
Happy anniversary of being President. This is your report card.

She slides it across the table. INSERT — a handmade report card, typed, in the Sidwell Friends font, with a little bluebird drawn in the corner.

INSERT — "MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK · GRADE: PRESIDENT · TEACHER: EMMA BULLOCK (WITH HELP FROM VICTORIA, WHO DID NOT HELP)."

MARC
(reading)
"Healthcare: B-plus. Phase one only. Work on phase two."

EMMA
It's only kids and people over sixty right now. That's not everybody. You said everybody.

MARC
By 2028 it's everybody.

EMMA
Then in 2028 you'll get an A.

MARC
(reading)
"Inflation: A." Thank you.

EMMA
Two-point-three is good. Mr. Lindqvist in Econ says two is the goal, so it's not an A-plus.

MARC
"National Debt: Incomplete."

EMMA
It went up.

MARC
It went up slower.

EMMA
It went up, Dad.

Esther hides her smile behind her mug.

MARC
(reading)
"World Peace: C-plus. Ukraine is a ceasefire, not peace. Gaza is better. China is still being weird." China is "still being weird"?

EMMA
That's a direct quote from you on the phone with Aunt Naledi.

MARC
You can't quote the President's phone calls.

EMMA
You talk really loud.

VICTORIA
Read the last one. I did the last one.

MARC
(reading)
"Bowling: A-plus-plus. The President bowled a one-sixty-four on Thanksgiving."
That's true.

VICTORIA
It's the only thing on there you got an A-plus-plus in.

MARC
What's at the bottom? "Teacher comments."

He reads it to himself. The room goes quiet. His face changes.

INSERT — "TEACHER COMMENTS: Dad works very hard and does not sleep enough. He is nicer to people who are mean to him than they deserve. He is better at being President than he thinks. Lyric says he still hasn't finished fixing it, but he is doing it. — E.B."

Marc reaches for glasses that aren't there. Then he just puts his hand over his mouth for a second.

MARC
I'm putting this on the Resolute Desk.

EMMA
You can't. It's not a historical document.

MARC
It is now.

Victoria puts the bowling ball on the Grant table, directly on top of the legal pad. Directly on top of "57."

VICTORIA
Also, I have a question about the Senate.

MARC
Go.

VICTORIA
If you need sixty and you have fifty-seven, why don't you just invite three of them bowling?

Marc looks at Esther. Esther looks at Marc.

ESTHER
Don't.

MARC
I'm not.

ESTHER
You are absolutely thinking about it.

SMASH CUT TO:

MAIN TITLES

MONTAGE — "THE YEAR" — JANUARY 2025 TO JANUARY 2026

— MONDAY, JANUARY 27, 2025. Sidwell Friends School, Washington. The President's daughters walk in through the front doors of the middle school for the first time. Victoria asks the head of school, within four minutes of arriving, whether there is bowling. There is not.

— THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 13. The Blue Room. The promised dinner with Donald Trump. Two hours and fourteen minutes. Steak, well done. Neither side ever discloses what was said. Afterward, Trump posts that the President is a "very smart young man" who is "wrong about almost everything," and that the steak was excellent.

POLITICO

Inside the Blue Room Dinner

Two Presidents, Two Hours, Zero Leaks

— WEDNESDAY, MARCH 12. The East Room. The Congressional Stock Trading Ban Act becomes the first bill signed into law by President Bullock. It passed the House 402–27 and the Senate 81–18. Lyric Baker (10) hands out the pens.

Twitter · @GraceBullock

Members of Congress can no longer trade individual stocks. The first law. 51 days. You're welcome, America.

488K Retweets · 3.1M Likes

— TUESDAY, MARCH 18. The Gaza ceasefire collapses. Fighting resumes. For eleven weeks, Secretary of State Naledi Mokoena-Hart (37) lives on airplanes between Cairo, Doha, and Jerusalem. On

TUESDAY, JUNE 3, the ceasefire is restored.

— MONDAY, APRIL 21. Pope Francis dies in Rome on Easter Monday at eighty-eight. The same morning, on deadline, Treasury Secretary Julian Park (37) delivers the 412-page blueprint for an American Sovereign Fund to Congress. Almost nobody notices. On SATURDAY, APRIL 26, the President and First Lady attend the Pope's funeral in St. Peter's Square.

— TUESDAY, APRIL 29. Day 100. Gallup: 63% approve.

— THURSDAY, MAY 1. Preview night of "Avengers: The Kang Dynasty." Midway through, Kang removes his helmet. It is Tyrese Avery. The internet does not recover for a month.

— THURSDAY, MAY 8. White smoke. Cardinal Robert Prevost of Chicago becomes Pope Leo XIV, the first American pope. The President's statement: "The White Sox have a Pope. The Dodgers have a President. Congratulations to Chicago, and to Catholics everywhere."

— WEDNESDAY, JULY 23. The House passes the American Families Reconciliation Act, 221–214. Seventeen Democrats vote no.

— THURSDAY, AUGUST 7, 2:14 AM EST. After a twenty-six-hour vote-a-rama, after the Senate parliamentarian strips out eleven provisions under the Byrd Rule, the Senate deadlocks on final passage, 50–50. Two Democrats vote no. No Republicans vote yes. For the first time in his life, Vice President Amond Baker (33) casts a tie-breaking vote.

VICE PRESIDENT AMOND BAKER (ON SCREEN)
On this vote, the yeas are fifty, the nays are fifty. The Senate being equally divided, the Vice President votes in the affirmative.

(beat)
And the bill, as amended, is passed.

TikTok · @harmonybaker

[video: the Second Lady, in the Senate gallery at 2 AM, mouthing "THAT'S MY HUSBAND" at the camera]

41.2M views

— TUESDAY, AUGUST 12. The House, called back from recess by Speaker Jeffries, passes the Senate version, 224–211.

— THURSDAY, AUGUST 14. The ninetieth anniversary, to the day, of Franklin Roosevelt signing the Social Security Act. The South Lawn. The President signs the American Families Reconciliation Act: a

public health plan, AmeriCare, phased in starting with every child and every adult sixty and over; universal pre-K money for the states; tuition-free public college for families earning under $150,000; childcare capped at seven percent of income; and the first phase of the zero-tax promise, no federal income tax on the first $50,000 of income. The pens go to a nurse, a kindergarten teacher, and a sixty-three-year-old diabetic truck driver from Gary, Indiana.

THE NEW YORK TIMES

Bullock Signs Biggest Expansion of the Safety Net Since 1965

Vice President's Tie-Breaking Vote Delivers Healthcare, College and Child Care Overhaul; Republicans Vow Repeal

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL (EDITORIAL BOARD)

The $4 Trillion Coin Flip

A Generational Entitlement Passed by One Vote, Paid For by Promises

— FRIDAY, AUGUST 29. Geneva. After seven months of talks, a ceasefire along the line of contact in Ukraine takes effect at midnight. It is not a peace deal. Russia keeps the territory it occupies, pending "final status" talks. In Moscow, President Putin calls it a victory. In Kyiv, President Zelenskyy calls it a pause. Both are right.

— TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 30, 11:41 PM EST. Nineteen minutes before midnight, the Senate passes a stopgap funding bill, 64–36, to keep the government open through Friday, January 30, 2026. No shutdown.

— MONDAY, OCTOBER 13. The last living hostages come home from Gaza.

— TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 4. Off-year elections, which almost always punish the President's party. Democrats win the governorships of Virginia and New Jersey anyway, by four points and six.

— FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 7. "Avengers: Secret Wars" opens worldwide. $1.19 billion in its first weekend. Tyrese Avery, as Kang the Conqueror, is the reason.

— THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 20. The House passes the American Sovereign Fund Act, 229–206. Nine Republicans vote yes. It goes to the Senate, where it needs sixty votes to overcome a filibuster. It has fifty-four.

— THURSDAY, DECEMBER 18. The President signs the National Defense Authorization Act, carrying most of what his campaign called the Superpower Act: shipyards, chip plants, AI research, and a modernized Navy.

— THURSDAY, JANUARY 1, 2026. AmeriCare goes live. By noon, 2.8 million people have logged into the enrollment site. It crashes twice. It comes back.

— MONDAY, JANUARY 5. The President turns thirty-four.

— TUESDAY, JANUARY 13. The December inflation report: 2.3%. The lowest since early 2021.

ACT ONE — "THE SUNDAY SHOWS"

INT. NBC NEWS — "MEET THE PRESS" — WASHINGTON BUREAU — DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 18, 2026 — 9:00 AM EST

The famous set. KRISTEN WELKER (49) across from the White House Chief of Staff, ELXA BULLOCK (35), in a dark green suit, no notes. The President's big sister. The most powerful unelected person in Washington, according to three magazine covers she pretends not to have read.

CHYRON: MEET THE PRESS — EXCLUSIVE: WHITE HOUSE CHIEF OF STAFF ELXA BULLOCK

KRISTEN WELKER
Madam Chief of Staff, welcome back. Tuesday marks one year. Grade your brother.

ELXA
I'm his Chief of Staff, Kristen. I grade his schedule. His daughter grades him, and she's a lot tougher than I am.

KRISTEN WELKER
Let me give you the numbers then. Inflation, two-point-three percent. Unemployment, three-point-eight. Gas, under two-eighty a gallon. The murder rate fell nineteen percent last year, the biggest drop ever recorded. His approval in our poll is fifty-eight percent, which is higher than any President at this point since George W. Bush after 9/11. So, the good news is real.

ELXA
It is.

KRISTEN WELKER
Here's the other side. The national debt is thirty-seven-point-one trillion dollars. Higher than the day he took office. The Supreme Court will hear Texas's challenge to his immigration order in March. The healthcare law passed by one vote, the Vice President's. And his signature economic idea, the Sovereign Fund, is stuck in the Senate. He promised to eliminate the debt. Is that promise already broken?

ELXA
The deficit this year is three hundred billion dollars smaller than the year before he took office. That's not where we're going. That's the first step of where we're going. The President never promised to pay off thirty-seven trillion dollars in twelve months. He promised a plan that pays it off, in law, with arithmetic anybody can check. That plan is the Sovereign Fund. It comes up for a cloture vote on Thursday.

KRISTEN WELKER
And you have how many votes?

ELXA
Enough to be optimistic and not enough to stop working.

KRISTEN WELKER
Our reporting is fifty-six or fifty-seven.

ELXA
Your reporting is very good.

KRISTEN WELKER
So you'll come up short.

ELXA
Kristen, a year ago people said the Constitution would come up short. Then they said he'd come up short in Texas. I've learned to stop counting him out before Thursday.

KRISTEN WELKER
A lot of progressives want him to get rid of the filibuster. Change the Senate rules, pass it with fifty-one. Senate Democrats have the votes to do it. Will he ask them to?

ELXA
No.

KRISTEN WELKER
Why not?

ELXA
Because the fund is supposed to outlive him. Anything you pass with fifty-one, the next majority can tear down with fifty-one. He wants this to be like Social Security. Something the other party campaigns on protecting.

KRISTEN WELKER
Let's talk about Congress. You have a Democratic House and a Democratic Senate. And yet, the healthcare law needed a tie-breaker. Seventeen House Democrats voted no. Is the President's own party his biggest problem?

ELXA
(a small smile)
The President's own party has given him the most productive first year since Lyndon Johnson. And the President's own party has members in districts Donald Trump won by eight points who are up for re-election in ten months. He understands that. He doesn't take a single vote personally. He takes every vote seriously.

KRISTEN WELKER
The midterms. Historically, the President's party loses about two dozen House seats. Your majority is twenty. Are Democrats going to lose the House?

ELXA
History is a very good predictor, Kristen. Until it isn't. Ask the Founders about the age requirement.

SUPER: 9:22 AM EST

INT. FOX NEWS — "SUNDAY MORNING FUTURES" — NEW YORK — SAME TIME

Across town, on Fox News, the Republican answer. Senate Minority Leader John Thune (65), in an earlier taped segment, says Republicans won't be "rushed" into a fund that puts the federal government into the investment business, and that several members of his conference have "real concerns" about Western lands. He leaves the door open "for the right bill." Washington reporters spend the rest of the day arguing about what "the right bill" means.

Then, live, the House Republican who has become the President's loudest critic in America: REPRESENTATIVE JOLENE PRUITT (41), Republican of Texas's 26th District, freshman, Freedom Caucus, a former Dallas County prosecutor with a Texas drawl that can cut glass. 3.4 million followers. A coffee mug on the desk in front of her that reads "I LOVE THE 10TH AMENDMENT."

CHYRON: REP. JOLENE PRUITT (R-TX): "THE SOVEREIGN FUND IS WASHINGTON BUYING THE COUNTRY WITH YOUR MONEY"

REP. JOLENE PRUITT
Let me tell you what this fund is. It's the federal government taking ownership of your land, your oil, your airwaves, and your patents, and putting them in a box that Treasury controls and Congress can't touch. They call it "sovereign." Do you know who else has sovereign wealth funds? Saudi Arabia. Norway. China. You know what those countries have that America doesn't? A government that owns everything.

MARIA BARTIROMO (O.S.)
The White House says it's modeled on the Alaska Permanent Fund, which Republicans in Alaska have defended for forty years.

REP. JOLENE PRUITT
Then pass it in Alaska. Look, I like the President. Everybody likes the President. That's the problem. Marc-Anthony Bullock is the most charming man who has ever put his hand in your pocket. He's got a fifty-eight percent approval rating and a thirty-seven-trillion-dollar debt. Only one of those numbers is going to be around in ten years.

Twitter · @RepJolenePruitt

58% approval. $37.1 TRILLION in debt. Only one of those numbers is going to outlive his presidency. #NoSovereignFund

61K Retweets · 288K Likes

Twitter · @GraceBullock

Replying to @RepJolenePruitt: The debt you're quoting grew $7.8 trillion in the four years before he took office. He's had it for twelve months. Want to talk about who put their hand in whose pocket?

140K Retweets · 912K Likes

Twitter · @RepJolenePruitt

Replying to @GraceBullock: The White House Press Secretary is subtweeting a freshman congresswoman on a Sunday. I'll take that as a compliment, Grace.

98K Retweets · 501K Likes

Twitter · @Tayia

Grace. Phone. Down. Now. — Your Communications Director, who loves you

66K Retweets · 1.1M Likes

INT. VICE PRESIDENT'S RESIDENCE — NAVAL OBSERVATORY — KITCHEN — DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, JANUARY 18 — 11:04 AM EST

Sunday pancakes. VICE PRESIDENT AMOND BAKER (33) at the stove. HARMONY BAKER (33) on a stool, scrolling. LYRIC BAKER (11), sixth grade, at the island with a math worksheet and the focus of a federal judge.

HARMONY
Grace and the Texas lady are fighting again.

AMOND
Grace is going to get her phone taken away by the United States Government.

LYRIC
(not looking up)
What's a cloture?

AMOND
It's when the Senate votes to stop talking about something so they can vote on it.

LYRIC
They have to vote to stop talking?

AMOND
Yep.

LYRIC
And they need sixty votes to stop talking?

AMOND
Yep.

LYRIC
(finally looking up)
That's so dumb.

HARMONY
Out of the mouths of babes.

AMOND
It's not dumb, Ly. It's... old. It's supposed to make sure the majority can't just do whatever it wants without listening to the other side.

LYRIC
Do they listen to the other side?

Amond flips a pancake. Takes a long time to answer.

AMOND
Sometimes. When somebody makes them.

LYRIC
Is Uncle Marc making them?

AMOND
He's trying.

LYRIC
You broke the tie on the doctor one. Can you break the tie on this one?

AMOND
Not on cloture, baby. The Vice President only votes when it's a tie, and cloture isn't about a tie. It's sixty or nothing.

LYRIC
(deeply offended on his behalf)
So you just sit there?

AMOND
I just sit there.

LYRIC
That's even dumber.

ACT TWO — "ONE YEAR"

INT. WHITE HOUSE — THE ROOSEVELT ROOM — MORNING

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20, 2026 — 8:02 AM EST

SUPER: ONE YEAR IN OFFICE

The portrait of Teddy Roosevelt on horseback over the fireplace. The Nobel Peace Prize he won in 1906 in a case on the mantel. Around the table, the senior staff and the two Cabinet members who matter most this week:

ELXA (35), Chief of Staff, at the head. DANTE REYES (44), Deputy Chief of Staff. PATTI GROVE (61), Counselor to the President, with a printed whip sheet and three colors of highlighter. GRACE BULLOCK (31), Press Secretary. TAYIA BOYD (33), Communications Director. TYLER CHAPMAN (34), Senior Advisor for Bipartisan Affairs, the only registered Republican on the White House senior staff, in a navy suit and cowboy boots. And TREASURY SECRETARY JULIAN PARK (38), who wrote the bill.

On a screen at the end of the room: the Senate. Ninety-nine faces and one empty square (a senator in the hospital for knee surgery, expected back Thursday). Fifty-seven green. Thirty-two red. Ten yellow.

The President walks in at 8:02 with a coffee. Everyone starts to stand.

MARC
Sit, sit, sit. We're not doing that today. Today's our anniversary. Patti, what's the number?

PATTI
Still fifty-seven, Mr. President. Fifty Democrats. Seven Republicans. Two Democrats are no, both from energy states, both up in 2026, both worried about the Western land provisions. The ten in yellow are all Republicans, all from the West or Alaska, and all with the same question.

MARC
Which is?

TYLER
"What's in it for my state?"

JULIAN
What's in it for their state is a fund that pays down the national debt and makes their constituents' tax cuts permanent.

TYLER
Julian, I love you. That's a national answer. They need an Alaska answer.

JULIAN
There is no Alaska answer that doesn't cost money.

TYLER
Then it costs money.

Marc sits. Looks between them.

MARC
Tyler. What's the Alaska answer?

TYLER
Two things. One. Lease, don't sell. The bill lets the fund sell federal land. Nobody out West will vote for that. Ever. Their grandfathers hunted on that land. Make it lease-only. Mineral rights, spectrum, patents, equity, yes. Land, never. You can't sell a single acre.

JULIAN
That takes about three hundred billion dollars out of the projections.

TYLER
It takes three hundred billion dollars and puts in ten votes.

MARC
And two?

TYLER
The dividend. Alaska has had it since 1982. Every resident gets a check from the fund every year. Republicans defend it like it's the Second Amendment. Put it in. A quarter of the fund's annual earnings go out as a check to every American citizen. The American Dividend. Your name's not on it. The fund's name is on it.

Silence. Julian puts down his pen.

JULIAN
(carefully)
Mr. President, half the earnings were going to pay down the debt. If a quarter goes out in checks, the debt timeline goes from twenty-eight years to thirty-four. And every economist on the Sunday shows is going to say we're handing out free money.

TYLER
Six more years to get it done. Versus never.

GRACE
Or. We do it with fifty-one.

The room turns.

GRACE
I'm just saying it out loud, because everybody on Twitter and half the Democratic caucus is saying it. Schumer has the votes to change the rules. Fifty-two Democrats. We change the filibuster for this bill only, we pass the original version, the one Julian actually wrote, with no giveaways. Done by Friday.

PATTI
And in January 2029, when it's a Republican Senate, they repeal it by Saturday.

GRACE
If they win.

PATTI
They always win eventually, baby. That's what eventually means.

DANTE
And it's not fifty-two. Our two no's on the bill are also no's on the rule change. So it's fifty. And then the Vice President breaks a tie to change the Senate rules forever. Do you want Amond's name on that? Because I don't.

Marc has been quiet. He looks at Tayia.

MARC
Tay. You're the only one here who votes for both parties. What does a regular person hear?

TAYIA
(beat)
If you change the rules, a regular person hears that you're like everybody else. If you put in the dividend, a regular person hears that they get a check. I'm sorry. That's it. That's the whole country.

Marc nods slowly. He looks at the Roosevelt portrait. Then at Julian.

MARC
Julian. You built the most important bill of my presidency and I'm about to cut it. I'm sorry.

JULIAN
Don't apologize, sir. Just tell me how much.

MARC
Lease-only. No sales. Ever. Write it as strongly as the law allows. And the dividend at twenty-five percent of earnings. But put a floor in: the debt share never drops below fifty percent, in any year, no matter who's President.

JULIAN
A future Congress can change that.

MARC
Then let them try to explain to every American why their check is going away. That's the whole point. We make it too popular to kill.

(to Grace)
No rule change. Not this year. Not this bill. If I can't get sixty, it isn't ready.

GRACE
(quietly)
Yes, sir.

MARC
Tyler. Who's the first call?

TYLER
Alaska. Both of them. But not on the phone. You've got the Democratic caucus lunch at 12:45. And Thune said he'd give you fifteen minutes at theirs.

The room freezes.

ELXA
He said what?

TYLER
I asked him last night. He said yes at 6:10 this morning. Fifteen minutes. The Senate Republican lunch. The LBJ Room. No cameras, no staff, no aides in the room. Just you.

DANTE
A Democratic President in the Republican lunch. That hasn't happened in... has that ever happened?

PATTI
(already standing, already dialing)
It hasn't happened in my lifetime, and I'm sixty-one. Agent Okonjo is going to have a stroke.

MARC
Tell Okonjo we're going to the Capitol.

(standing; to Julian)
Can you have the new language by noon?

JULIAN
I can have it by eleven.

MARC
That's why you're Treasury Secretary.

INT. ABC NEWS — "GOOD MORNING AMERICA" — TIMES SQUARE STUDIO — MORNING

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20 — 8:31 AM EST

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (64) and ROBIN ROBERTS (65) at the anchor desk. Behind them, a giant photo of the Rotunda, one year ago.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And breaking this morning, ABC News has learned that the President will go to Capitol Hill today to meet with Senate Republicans at their weekly lunch. Jonathan Karl, how unusual is that?

JONATHAN KARL (57) (ON SCREEN)
George, Presidents go to their own party's lunch. They don't go to the other side's. My producers have been through the records and can't find a modern example. And Thune agreeing to it tells you something too: Republicans have heard about the changes to the Sovereign Fund bill. Their members want to see the President look them in the eye.

INT. U.S. CAPITOL — SENATE DEMOCRATIC CAUCUS LUNCH — THE MANSFIELD ROOM — DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20 — 12:47 PM EST

Fifty-two Democratic senators at round tables, the caucus's regular Tuesday lunch. Chicken. The President stands at the front without a podium. Majority Leader Chuck Schumer (75) beside him.

We stay outside the room with the press for most of it, the way history does. Through the doors, applause. Twice. Then a long silence. Then the sound of a single senator's raised voice, muffled.

At 1:22 PM, the doors open. The two Democratic holdouts walk out side by side, phones to their ears, and decline to comment. One of them is smiling. The other is not.

Schumer tells reporters in the hallway that the caucus is "united behind the President's goal," and that the new language "makes a lot of members a lot more comfortable." Asked about the filibuster, he says only that the President has been "very clear" about what he wants.

> **Twitter · @HillReporterDana**
>
> NEW: One of the two Dem holdouts on the Sovereign Fund tells me the lease-only change "gets me most of the way there." The other one walked away without answering. Pres. now heading to the LBJ Room for the GOP lunch
>
> **8K Retweets · 31K Likes**

INT. U.S. CAPITOL — SECOND FLOOR HALLWAY, OUTSIDE S-211 — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 1:31 PM EST

A mob of reporters behind a rope line. Capitol Police. AGENT OKONJO (50) walking a half-step behind the President with an expression that could freeze the Potomac.

AGENT OKONJO
Mr. President, fifteen minutes. I'll be outside the door. If you need anything, say "Thursday."

MARC
Why "Thursday"?

AGENT OKONJO
Because nobody would say it by accident in there today, sir.

Marc grins. A Senate Republican staffer opens the door to S-211, the Lyndon B. Johnson Room, once the office of the most feared Majority Leader in history. Forty-eight Republican senators at the long tables go quiet. Thune stands at the front.

The door closes behind the President. Okonjo stands in front of it like a load-bearing wall.

INT. S-211, THE LBJ ROOM — THE SENATE REPUBLICAN LUNCH — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 1:32 PM EST

For the record: what follows was not recorded. It is reconstructed from the accounts of nine people in the room, which agree on the substance and disagree on the tone.

Thune introduces him in one sentence. Marc doesn't sit. He stands at the end of the table with his hands in his pockets.

MARC
Thank you for having me. I know a lot of you didn't want me here, and I know some of you said so to Leader Thune this morning, so thank you to him most of all.

(beat)
I'm not going to give a speech. I've got fifteen minutes and Agent Okonjo is timing me. I want to tell you two things I changed, and then I want you to tell me what I got wrong.

He tells them. Lease-only: no federal land ever sold, in perpetuity, the strongest language Treasury's lawyers can write. A quarter of the fund's annual earnings paid to every American citizen as a dividend, the Alaska model. A fifty percent floor for debt reduction.

Silence. Then, from the far end of the table, A REPUBLICAN SENATOR FROM THE MOUNTAIN WEST, seventies, a rancher's hands.

A REPUBLICAN SENATOR (MOUNTAIN WEST)
Mr. President. My granddaddy's cattle grazed BLM land. So did mine. So do my son's. You're telling me no Treasury Secretary, ever, sells one acre of it to a hedge fund.

MARC
Not one acre. And if a future Treasury Secretary tries, the bill gives your state attorney general standing to sue to stop it.

A REPUBLICAN SENATOR (MOUNTAIN WEST)
You put that in this morning?

MARC
I put that in at 11:04 this morning. My Treasury Secretary hasn't slept.

A low laugh from somewhere at the table. Then a SECOND REPUBLICAN SENATOR, younger, from the South, a fiscal hawk, not laughing.

A REPUBLICAN SENATOR (SOUTH)
With respect, Mr. President, you just added a welfare check to a debt bill. You took the one part of this I could defend at home and you made it a giveaway.

MARC
Senator, with respect back, your state has had a dividend for over forty years. Oh, wait. That's Alaska. Your state doesn't.

(beat; the room reacts)
I'm kidding. Sort of. You're right that it costs something. It pushes the debt timeline back six years. Twenty-eight years becomes thirty-four. I'm not going to lie to you about that. But here's what it buys: no future Congress, Democratic or Republican, will ever be able to raid that

fund, because the second they try, every single voter in your state will lose a check. You want discipline? That's discipline. It's enforced by two hundred and sixty million voters.

Another silence. Then Thune looks at his watch.

From the middle of the table, a third voice. A woman. Calm. Those in the room later agree it was the turning point, and agree on nothing else about it. She asks a single question: whether the President would put the dividend percentage in the statute itself, so a Treasury Secretary couldn't change it by rule.

MARC
Yes, ma'am. It's in the statute. It's in the version Julian's sending to the Leader right now.

At 1:47 PM, the door opens. Okonjo looks at his watch: fifteen minutes. Exactly.

AGENT OKONJO
(low)
Anything, sir?

MARC
(low)
Not Thursday. Not yet.

INT. U.S. CAPITOL — HOUSE SIDE — THE RAYBURN ROOM CORRIDOR — DAY

SUPER: 1:58 PM EST

The President's route back to the motorcade runs past the House side. Waiting by the elevators, a phone already raised and recording, flanked by two aides: REP. JOLENE PRUITT (41). She's been there for twenty minutes. She meant to be.

REP. JOLENE PRUITT
Mr. President! Happy anniversary.

Okonjo shifts. Marc stops anyway.

MARC
Congresswoman Pruitt. Thank you. I saw your mug on Fox.

REP. JOLENE PRUITT
I'll send you one.

MARC
I'll drink coffee out of it in the Oval Office. You'll be very upset.

REP. JOLENE PRUITT
Were you just in the Republican lunch handing out checks?

MARC
I was in the Republican lunch listening. You should try it. They're very nice people.

REP. JOLENE PRUITT
Sir, I'm going to say this with respect, on camera, so it's on the record. Every country that tried to own its way to prosperity ended up with a government nobody could vote out. You're the most popular man in America. That's what scares me. Not you. The next guy. The one who inherits a fund with three trillion dollars in it and no one who's charming enough to keep it honest.

A beat. Marc looks at her. Not angry. Genuinely considering it.

MARC
That's the best argument against my bill I've heard in a year.

REP. JOLENE PRUITT
(thrown for half a second)
...Thank you.

MARC
So help me write the guardrails. Come to the White House. Bring the mug. You want an inspector general with subpoena power? Put it in. You want the fund's books public every quarter, line by line? Put it in. You want the next guy to be scared of the people? So do I.

REP. JOLENE PRUITT
I'm not voting for it.

MARC
I know. Help me make it better anyway. That's the job.

He moves on. Okonjo, relieved, moves with him. Pruitt lowers her phone, stares after him for a long moment, and then, for some reason she couldn't explain to her chief of staff later, doesn't post the video for three hours.

Twitter · @RepJolenePruitt

[video] Told the President to his face the Sovereign Fund is a blank check for the next guy. He invited me to the White House to write the guardrails. I'm still a NO. But I'm going. Bringing the mug.

211K Retweets · 1.4M Likes

Twitter · @PunchbowlNews

Pruitt, the Freedom Caucus's loudest Bullock critic, says she'll meet WH on Sovereign Fund oversight language. She's still a no. The Senate is the whole game.

4K Retweets · 19K Likes

Reddit · r/politics

"Jolene Pruitt confronts Bullock outside Rayburn Room; he tells her it's 'the best argument against my bill I've heard in a year' and invites her to write the guardrails"

61.2K upvotes · Top comment: "This man would invite the iceberg to dinner and by dessert the iceberg would be co-sponsoring a bill to protect ships."

INT. U.S. CAPITOL — CANNON TUNNEL — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 2:06 PM EST

The underground tunnel to the House office buildings. A woman in a red coat is half-jogging to catch up. REPRESENTATIVE DANIELLE OKORO-BANKS (36), Democrat of Michigan's 10th District, freshman, a former Detroit auto plant engineer who flipped a Macomb County seat Republicans had held since it was drawn. One of the seventeen Democrats who voted no on the healthcare bill in July and yes on the final version in August.

REP. OKORO-BANKS
Mr. President. Do you have thirty seconds?

MARC
Congresswoman. For you, forty-five.

REP. OKORO-BANKS
I need to ask you something, and I need you not to be offended.

MARC
That's a lot of pressure on a tunnel.

REP. OKORO-BANKS
Please don't come to my district this fall.

Okonjo's eyebrows go up a sixteenth of an inch. Marc stops walking.

REP. OKORO-BANKS
It's not you. It's that my district is Macomb County, Trump won Macomb by eight in 2020, and the Republicans are going to run every ad they have that says I'm your rubber stamp. If you show up at a rally, that's the ad. I voted with you ninety-one percent of the time. I need the other nine percent to keep my job.

MARC
What happened in July?

REP. OKORO-BANKS
In July, the bill cost too much and the pay-for was a fantasy. In August, the Senate fixed it. I voted yes. I'll vote no again when you're wrong. That's the deal I made with Macomb County.

Marc looks at her a long time.

MARC
Congresswoman, I'm not going to come to your district.

REP. OKORO-BANKS
(exhaling)
Thank you, sir.

MARC
I'm going to send the Vice President to the UAW hall in Warren. He doesn't make a speech. He doesn't say your name. He works an eight-hour shift on the line. And then you show up for the last hour, and you tell him everything he got wrong.

A beat. She laughs despite herself.

REP. OKORO-BANKS
Does he know he's doing that?

MARC
He will in about four minutes.

She nods. Walks away. Stops. Turns back.

REP. OKORO-BANKS
Mr. President. The Sovereign Fund. Is there a dividend in it now? Because I heard there's a dividend in it now.

MARC
There's a dividend in it now.

REP. OKORO-BANKS
(beat)
Macomb County's going to like that.

MARC
That's the idea.

Marc

Amond. How do you feel about the UAW.

Amond

I am a proud supporter of the UAW. Why do I feel like this is a trap.

Marc

You're working an 8 hour shift at Stellantis in Warren in May. On the line. Don't make a speech.

Amond

I'm an actor Marc.

Marc

Then act like you know how to build a Jeep.

Amond

I hate this job. I love you. I hate this job.

INT. WHITE HOUSE — JAMES S. BRADY PRESS BRIEFING ROOM — DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20 — 3:31 PM EST

Full room. Every seat taken, aisles packed. GRACE BULLOCK (31) at the podium. On the podium, a small frame Grace's staff put there as a joke, and she kept: a photo of her at ten and Marc at twelve, both in Lakers jerseys, both mid-argument.

GRACE
Good afternoon. One year ago today my brother put his hand on a hundred-and-twenty-year-old Bible in the Capitol Rotunda. I'm going to run through some numbers, and then I'm going to take your questions, and then I'm going to try very hard not to get into a fight on the internet tonight.

Laughter in the room.

INSERT — the slide behind Grace: "YEAR ONE."

Inflation: 2.3%, the lowest since early 2021. Unemployment: 3.8%. Gas: $2.78 a gallon. Murder rate: down 19%. Housing starts: 1.71 million a year, the most since 2006. Enrolled in AmeriCare in its first 19 days: 6.4 million. Uninsured rate: down from 8.0% to 6.1%. Federal deficit: down $300 billion. Immigration court backlog: down from 3.7 million cases to 2.9 million. Lead pipes replaced: 1.1 million. The last homes in Flint: done. Laws signed: 61. Bills vetoed: 0.

GRACE
Zero vetoes. Questions. Yes, in the front.

WHITE HOUSE REPORTER (AP)
Grace, the President was in the Senate Republican lunch today. What did he promise them?

GRACE
He promised them that no federal land will ever be sold by the fund, he promised every American a dividend, and he promised them he'd stop talking after fifteen minutes. He kept all three.

FOX NEWS CORRESPONDENT
Grace, the debt is higher today than a year ago. The healthcare law passed by one vote. Thirty-one states have sued over the immigration and energy orders. Isn't it true that every big thing the President has done is either temporary, tied up in court, or passed by the thinnest possible margin?

GRACE
It's true that the healthcare law passed by one vote. In August of 1941, the House extended the military draft by one vote, four months before Pearl Harbor. A vote is a vote. Six-point-four million people have a doctor today who didn't have one on New Year's Eve. Ask them about the margin.

FOX NEWS CORRESPONDENT
And the debt?

GRACE
The debt is why he's going to the Hill. The debt is Thursday.

WHITE HOUSE REPORTER (CNN)
Is the President going to ask Senate Democrats to change the filibuster rules if Thursday fails?

GRACE
(a beat; she was on the other side of this argument at 8:30 this morning)
No. The President believes a law meant to last a hundred years should be passed by a big enough majority to last a hundred years. He'd rather lose Thursday than win the wrong way.

WHITE HOUSE REPORTER (CNN)
You personally argued the opposite on social media last summer.

GRACE
I'm his little sister. I argue the opposite of him about everything. He's still right this time. Don't tell him I said that.

INT. ABC NEWS — "WORLD NEWS TONIGHT" — SPECIAL EDITION — NEW YORK — NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20 — 6:30 PM EST

The bold red open. DAVID MUIR (52) at the anchor desk.

CHYRON: WORLD NEWS TONIGHT — SPECIAL REPORT: "YEAR ONE: THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY"

DAVID MUIR
Good evening. One year ago tonight, Marc-Anthony Bullock, thirty-three years old, was sworn in as the forty-seventh President. Tonight, at thirty-four, he is the most popular first-year President in a generation, presiding over an economy many Americans tell us finally feels like it's working for them. And tonight, he is facing the toughest vote of his presidency, with a Congress that has given him more than any President since the 1960s, and might be about to tell him no. We have it all covered. We begin with the numbers.

GRAPHIC — "THE STATE OF THE COUNTRY: JAN. 2025 vs. JAN. 2026"

INFLATION: 2.9% → 2.3% · UNEMPLOYMENT: 4.0% → 3.8% · GAS (NATIONAL AVG.): $3.11 → $2.78 · 30-YR MORTGAGE: 6.9% → 5.7% · UNINSURED: 8.0% → 6.1% · CONSUMER SENTIMENT: 71.1 → 86.4 · NATIONAL DEBT: $36.2T → $37.1T · GALLUP APPROVAL: 66% (honeymoon) → 59%

DAVID MUIR
Consumer sentiment, how Americans feel about the economy, at its highest level in nearly five years. But one number went the wrong way. The national debt. Rebecca Jarvis.

REBECCA JARVIS (ON SCREEN)
David, the deficit shrank by three hundred billion dollars, mostly because the economy grew faster than expected and tax revenue came in higher. But the healthcare and college law adds spending on top of that starting this year. The White House's answer to the debt is the Sovereign Fund. Without it, independent analysts say the President's promise to eliminate the debt is, in their word, impossible. With it, they say it's possible in thirty-four years. Possible. Not certain.

DAVID MUIR
Which brings us to Congress. Jonathan Karl at the White House.

JONATHAN KARL (ON SCREEN)
David, here's the President's first year with Congress in one sentence: his party gave him almost everything, and the other party gave him almost nothing, until now. Sixty-one laws. The stock trading ban passed with huge bipartisan margins. The defense bill, bipartisan. But the healthcare law passed with zero Republican votes and needed the Vice President to break a tie. Today, for the first time, the President walked into the Republican lunch, and he changed his own bill to get their votes. The question for Thursday is whether that's the start of a new relationship with Republicans, or just one deal.

DAVID MUIR
And Jon, the midterms. Ten months away.

JONATHAN KARL (ON SCREEN)
Democrats have a twenty-seat House majority. Since World War II, the President's party has lost an average of about two dozen seats in his first midterm. Democratic strategists tell me privately the President's approval is the only thing standing between them and history. And Republicans tell me privately, with a lot of respect, that they've stopped running against him. They're running against Congress.

DAVID MUIR
And in a moment, we'll take you to Flint, Michigan, where the last lead pipe came out of the ground in November, and to Altadena, California, where a woman the President met in the ashes a year ago just got the keys to a new home.

CUT TO: a taped package. EXT. LAKE AVENUE, ALTADENA — DAY. A new house with a back porch. MRS. ERNESTINE POWELL (80) on the porch steps with a ribbon and a pair of giant scissors. The back porch, she tells the reporter, is built to her late husband's exact measurements from 1974. She doesn't know who found the measurements. (Dante does. It was Marc's notebook.)

INT. CABLE NEWS — PRIME TIME — MONTAGE — NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20 — 8:00 PM TO 10:00 PM EST

— CNN. JAKE TAPPER (56) with HARRY ENTEN (37) at the magic wall.

HARRY ENTEN
Jake, look at this. Generic congressional ballot: Democrats plus five. At this point in a President's first term, the President's party is usually trailing. Bullock is above water in thirty-four states. Thirty-four! Including Texas, which, I'll remind everybody, he won. But here's the catch. Congress's approval: thirty-one percent. People love him. They don't love Congress. So the question in November is, are voters voting for him, or against them?

JAKE TAPPER
And Republicans are running against "them."

HARRY ENTEN
Republicans would be out of their minds to run against him. So they're running against Washington. And it's working in about thirty districts.

— FOX NEWS, "SPECIAL REPORT." BRET BAIER (55).

BRET BAIER
One year in, the President's supporters point to the economy. His critics point out that he inherited an economy already bringing inflation down, a Federal Reserve that was already cutting rates, and a falling crime rate that began before he took office. They say he's a talented man who caught a wave. Tonight, our panel on whether the Bullock boom is Bullock's.

The Fox panel is tough and fair. A former Treasury official in the last Republican administration says the stock market and the job numbers would look "about the same" under any President, and that the healthcare law is "a fiscal time bomb with a pretty ribbon on it." A conservative columnist says the President's popularity is real and Republicans who pretend otherwise "are going to get wiped out in November." They argue for eleven minutes. Nobody wins.

— MS NOW. RACHEL MADDOW (52), with a chalkboard history of the Senate filibuster, from 1806 to tonight. She concludes that the President is making "a beautiful, principled, possibly catastrophic bet" that the Senate still works, and that "on Thursday, we find out whether he's an idealist or a genius, and it's possible he's both."

THE WASHINGTON POST

Year One: Bullock Has Remade the Safety Net and Charmed the Country. Now He Needs Ten Republicans.

Analysis: The President's Hardest Test Is a 60-Vote Senate He Refuses to Change

THE ATLANTIC

The Thirty-Four-Year-Old Institutionalist

Marc-Anthony Bullock wants to change everything except the rules. That may be his most radical idea.

NATIONAL REVIEW

The Most Dangerous Popular President

Conservatives Can't Out-Charm Him. They'll Have to Out-Argue Him.

AXIOS

Behind the Scenes: How a Republican Staffer in the White House Got the President Into the GOP Lunch

Tyler Chapman, 34, Bullock's Childhood Friend and Only GOP Senior Aide, Brokered It in Eleven Hours

BLOOMBERG

Sovereign Fund Rewrite: Lease-Only Lands, a Dividend for Every American, and a 50% Debt Floor

Treasury's Park Sends New Text to Senate; Western Republicans 'Reviewing'

THE ROOT

One Year In, the Bullock Administration Is the Blackest, Youngest Government in History, and It's Working

Twelve Months, 61 Laws, Zero Vetoes

THE INTERNET — "YEAR ONE" — MONTAGE

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20 — ALL DAY

Twitter · @POTUS

One year ago today, I took an oath in the Rotunda. Today I went somewhere no Democratic President has gone in a very long time: the Senate Republican lunch. They were very polite. The chicken was good. We're not done.

811K Retweets · 6.2M Likes

TikTok · @EmmaBullock (private account, leaked by a classmate)

[video: a handmade report card on the Resolute Desk] "he put it on the RESOLUTE DESK I'm going to die"

88.4M views

Twitter · @VictoriaBullockFan

Victoria Bullock gave her father an A-plus-plus in bowling on his presidential report card and a C-plus in world peace. She is the toughest member of the press corps.

112K Retweets · 1.9M Likes

Instagram · @harmonybaker

[photo: Amond in the Senate chair at 2 AM in August, gavel raised] One year ago my husband became Vice President. He has voted exactly once. It counted.

7.4M Likes

Twitter · @TyreseAvery

Kang conquered 4,000 timelines and it still took less effort than getting 60 votes in the Senate. Happy anniversary, Mr. President. #YearOne

902K Retweets · 5.8M Likes

Reddit · r/marvelstudios

"Tyrese is posting about cloture votes two days before Oscar nominations. This man has no fear."

44.1K upvotes · Top comment: "He played a man who rules every reality. A Senate procedural vote is light work."

Reddit · r/politics

"MEGATHREAD: One Year of the Bullock Presidency: 61 laws, 2.3% inflation, AmeriCare live, Sovereign Fund cloture vote Thursday"

98.3K upvotes · Top comment: "Nuke the filibuster. I don't care. He's too nice." · Reply: "He's too nice is the reason he has 59% in a country where nobody gets 59%." · Reply: "Both of you are right and that's the whole presidency."

Twitter · @ProgressiveCaucusWatch

We love the AmeriCare phase-in. We do NOT love giving Republicans a veto over the Sovereign Fund. End the filibuster.

22K Retweets · 81K Likes

Twitter · @libertarianguy1776

I didn't vote for him. I still think the fund is a terrible idea. But lease-only + a dividend + a debt floor is the most libertarian thing a Democrat has proposed since Clinton signed welfare reform. I hate that I'm thinking about it.

31K Retweets · 204K Likes

Truth Social · (summary)

Former President Trump posts that the President is "a nice young man" who "doesn't know how to make a deal," and that a real dealmaker "would have had sixty votes in a week." The post is shared 41,000 times.

—

Twitter · @TylerChapman

My dad was a Navy machinist for 22 years. He used to say you don't fix an engine by yelling at it. You get under it. Happy one year, Mr. President. Still under it.

51K Retweets · 498K Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanUSN

That's my boy.

88K Retweets · 1.2M Likes

INT. WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20 — 9:41 PM EST

The Resolute Desk. On it, propped against the pen holder: Emma's report card in its plastic sleeve. The President, jacket off, sleeves rolled up, sits on the edge of the desk with the phone. Tyler on the couch with a laptop and the whip sheet. Patti in the chair by the fireplace with her highlighters. It's late. They've been doing this for two hours.

On the whip sheet: "58." Somebody has crossed out "57." One of the two Democratic holdouts, the one who was smiling, called at 7:15: yes.

We hear only the President's side of the next call.

PATTI
(whispering, holding up a card)
Alaska. The senior senator. She's at home in her apartment. She's had the new text for six hours.

Marc nods. Picks up the phone.

MARC
Senator. Thank you for taking my call so late. ... No, ma'am, I'm in the Oval. I don't think I've left it since lunch. ... Yes, I know you've had the text since three-thirty.

(listening)
... Yes. It's in the statute. Twenty-five percent. ... No, a future Treasury Secretary cannot change it by rule. It would take an act of Congress. ... Yes, ma'am. Sixty votes, if the filibuster stays. And I intend for it to stay.

(listening; a long time)
... I hear you. I hear you. I know what the Permanent Fund means in Alaska. I've read the history. Governor Hammond. 1976. The voters approved it two to one. ... No, I didn't know that. Your father?

A long pause. Marc's face softens. He sits down in the chair behind the desk.

MARC
... That's a beautiful story, Senator. ... No, I won't repeat it.

(listening)
... You want an Alaska Native advisory seat on the fund's board. Guaranteed by statute. Not appointed by the President, chosen by the Alaska Native corporations.

He looks at Tyler. Tyler, on the couch, is already typing to Julian. Tyler looks up. Nods once: Julian says yes.

MARC
... Yes. My Treasury Secretary says yes. It'll be in the manager's amendment tomorrow. ... Senator, can I count on you Thursday?

(a long silence; then:)
... I understand. You want to see it in writing. That's fair. That's more than fair. ... Thank you. Good night, Senator.

He hangs up. Tyler and Patti stare at him.

PATTI
Well?

MARC
She wants to see it in writing.

TYLER
That's a yes.

PATTI
That's a maybe with very good manners.

TYLER
From her, that's a yes.

PATTI
I'll believe it when she votes.

Patti does not move the name from yellow to green. She draws a small star next to it.

MARC
Who's next?

TYLER
The senator from Maine. She's one of our seven, and she's wobbling on the dividend. You should not, under any circumstances, call her after ten.

MARC
(checks watch: 10:02)
Damn.

PATTI
Tomorrow at seven. She'll appreciate that you waited.

INT. WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — LATER

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 20 — 11:14 PM EST

Tyler and Patti are gone. Marc alone at the desk. His phone buzzes. The caller ID reads "GRANDMA ODESSA (ATLANTA)."

MARC
Grandma. It's eleven o'clock.

ODESSA (V.O.)
I know what time it is. I'm ninety-seven years old, not dead. I've been watching C-SPAN since nine o'clock this morning. Cornelius set it up on the big television and now he can't get me to stop.

INTERCUT — INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — ODESSA'S BEDROOM — ATLANTA — NIGHT. ODESSA GRANT SMILLEY (97), propped up in bed in a pink bed jacket. Reading glasses on a chain. On the television: a senator speaking to an almost empty Senate chamber.

MARC
You've been watching the Senate for fourteen hours?

ODESSA
Somebody has to. The senators certainly aren't.

He laughs.

ODESSA
I heard you went into the Republican lunch.

MARC
I did.

ODESSA
Good. Your grandfather used to say you don't change a man's mind from across the street. You have to sit at his table.

(beat)
Baby, how many do you have?

MARC
Fifty-eight. Maybe fifty-nine. Maybe sixty if a senator from Alaska likes what she reads tomorrow.

ODESSA
Do you know when I learned the word "cloture"?

MARC
When?

ODESSA
June of 1964. I was thirty-five years old. Josiah and I were sitting in the parlor in front of a radio. The Southern senators had been filibustering the Civil Rights Act for sixty days. Sixty days of talking. And on the tenth of June, the Senate voted to stop. Seventy-one votes. They needed sixty-seven back then. Josiah cried. I'd never seen him cry in my life.

Marc is very still.

ODESSA
Do you know who got them over the top? Republicans. A Republican from Illinois named Everett Dirksen stood up and said it was an idea whose time had come. Josiah never voted for a Republican in his life. But he had Everett Dirksen's picture in his study until the day he died.

MARC
I didn't know that.

ODESSA
Nobody knows that. Cornelius took it down in 2009. I made him put it back up last Christmas.

(beat)
You did the right thing, not changing the rules. Josiah would've said the same thing. A law the other side helped write is a law the other side has to defend.

MARC
And if I lose on Thursday?

ODESSA
Then you lose on Thursday and you go back on Friday. They filibustered that bill for sixty days, baby. You've been at this for one.

Marc closes his eyes. Smiles.

MARC
Yes, ma'am.

ODESSA
Now go to bed. And tell Victoria her idea about the bowling isn't as crazy as everybody thinks.

MARC
How do you know about the bowling?

ODESSA
I'm ninety-seven. I know everything. Good night, Mr. President.

ACT THREE — "CLOTURE"

EXT. TYRESE AVERY'S HOUSE — HOLLYWOOD HILLS — PREDAWN

SUPER: THURSDAY, JANUARY 22, 2026 — 5:30 AM PST / 8:30 AM EST

A glass house above the lights of Los Angeles. Inside, TYRESE AVERY (34), in a hoodie, on the couch, refusing to watch the livestream on the TV and watching it on his phone with one eye closed. His publicist on speakerphone. His mother beside him, holding his hand so tight her knuckles are white.

On the phone screen: the Academy's livestream from the Samuel Goldwyn Theater in Beverly Hills. The 98th Academy Awards nominations. "Performance by an actor in a leading role."

PRESENTER (ON SCREEN)
...Tyrese Avery, "Avengers: Secret Wars."

Tyrese's mother screams. Tyrese doesn't move. He just puts the phone face down on his knee and puts both his hands over his face, and his shoulders start to shake.

The first text arrives in nine seconds.

Marc

YOU'RE NOMINATED FOR BEST ACTOR FOR PLAYING A SUPERVILLAIN IN A MARVEL MOVIE. IN A MOVIE OWNED BY A COMPANY MY FAMILY STARTED. I CAN'T SAY ANY OF THIS PUBLICLY BECAUSE OF THE BLIND TRUST. I LOVE YOU. I'M SCREAMING IN THE OVAL.

Tyrese

they used to call me "the pop star who's trying." bro

Marc

Nobody's calling you that anymore. Now go get some sleep. I have to go win a Senate vote.

Tyrese

conquer them

VARIETY

Oscar Nominations: Tyrese Avery Makes History as First MCU Performance Nominated for Lead Actor

'Secret Wars' Kang Joins Joaquin Phoenix's 'Joker' as Rare Comic-Book Lead Nominee; Donohue Earns 9 Nominations

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

From Pop Star Punchline to Best Actor Nominee: How Tyrese Avery Became Kang

'He Made Every Other Villain Look Like a Rough Draft'

Twitter · @MarvelStudios

Kang the Conqueror. Oscar nominee. Congratulations, @TyreseAvery.

1.8M Retweets · 9.2M Likes

Reddit · r/marvelstudios

"TYRESE AVERY. BEST ACTOR NOMINEE. FOR KANG."

211K upvotes · Top comment: "In 2022 they said Kang would never work. In 2026 he's at the Oscars. All timelines lead to Tyrese."

Twitter · @JolenePruittFan2026

not me a conservative from Texas crying about the Kang nomination. Tyrese is the only thing this country agrees on

9K Retweets · 61K Likes

INT. U.S. SENATE — THE CHAMBER — DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, JANUARY 22, 2026 — 11:00 AM EST

The Senate floor. All one hundred desks filled, which almost never happens. The galleries packed. The press gallery shoulder to shoulder. In the presiding officer's chair, at the top of the rostrum, VICE PRESIDENT AMOND BAKER (33). He cannot vote on cloture. He came anyway. He wanted to see it.

In the family gallery: Secretary of Homeland Security Simone Smilley (38), Treasury Secretary Julian Park (38), and, in the front row, Tyler Chapman (34) with his father, ROY CHAPMAN (68), still in his Navy veteran's cap.

The clerk reads the motion: to invoke cloture on the Majority Leader's substitute amendment to H.R. 4410, the American Sovereign Fund Act.

CHYRON: C-SPAN 2 — LIVE — U.S. SENATE — CLOTURE VOTE: AMERICAN SOVEREIGN FUND ACT — 60 VOTES NEEDED

INT. WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — INTERCUT — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 11:02 AM EST

The President on the couch. Elxa standing behind it. Patti in her chair with the whip sheet, now covered in green, a single star

still in yellow. Grace and Tayia by the window. Dante at the door. Julian's empty chair. On the TV, C-SPAN 2.

At the top of Patti's sheet, in red marker: "59."

The senator from Maine called at 7:01 this morning, one minute after the President did: still yes, dividend and all. The last Democratic holdout, the one who wasn't smiling, called at 8:40: yes, because of the lease-only language. Three of the seven Republicans had threatened to walk if land sales stayed in the bill; all three stayed. And at 10:14 AM, the rancher from the lunch walked onto the floor and told the press, "My granddaddy's land is safe. I'm still a yes."

Fifty-two Democrats. Seven Republicans. Fifty-nine. One star in yellow.

INT. U.S. SENATE — THE CHAMBER — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 11:04 AM EST

The clerk calls the roll alphabetically. Every name echoes. The vote tally on the C-SPAN graphic climbs. "Mr. Allred." "Aye." "Ms. Alsobrooks." "Aye." "Ms. Baldwin." "Aye." "Mr. Banks." "No." "Mr. Barrasso." "No."

MONTAGE: the roll call, name after name. The ayes and nays climbing together.

The senior senator from Alaska is not at her desk. She is in the cloakroom.

SUPER: 11:19 AM EST

CHYRON: CLOTURE VOTE: AYES 59 · NAYS 40 · NOT VOTING 1

The first full roll call is finished. Fifty-nine ayes. Forty nays. One senator who has not voted. The chamber is buzzing. Every head turns to the cloakroom door.

INT. WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 11:19 AM EST

GRACE
Where is she?

PATTI
Cloakroom.

GRACE
Why is she in the cloakroom?

PATTI
Because she's reading it one more time, baby. In writing. Like she said.

The President isn't watching the TV. He's looking at the Resolute Desk. At Emma's report card. "National Debt: Incomplete."

INT. U.S. SENATE — THE CHAMBER — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 11:23 AM EST

The cloakroom door opens. The senior senator from Alaska walks onto the floor, a stapled copy of the manager's amendment in her hand, and goes to the well. The chamber goes silent. Every senator. Every reporter. Every person in the gallery.

She says one word to the clerk. We don't hear it in the room.

We hear it in the Oval Office, from the TV, from the clerk:

SENATE CLERK (ON TV)
...Ms. Murkowski. Aye.

A sound goes through the Senate chamber that isn't quite applause, because applause isn't allowed, but it's close.

VICE PRESIDENT AMOND BAKER
(reading the card handed up to him; steady, but only barely)
On this vote, the yeas are sixty, the nays are forty. Three-fifths of the senators duly chosen and sworn having voted in the affirmative, the motion is agreed to.

CHYRON: CLOTURE INVOKED: 60–40 — AMERICAN SOVEREIGN FUND ACT ADVANCES IN THE SENATE

SUPER: 11:24 AM EST

INT. WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — CONTINUOUS

The room explodes. Grace screams into Tayia's shoulder. Dante hugs Elxa off the ground. Patti, sixty-one years old and a veteran of every Senate fight since the Clinton administration, draws a single green line through the star in yellow, caps her highlighter, and puts her face in her hands.

The President doesn't get up. He sits on the couch with his elbows on his knees and looks at the TV, at his best friend in the Vice President's chair, at the gallery, where Tyler Chapman is hugging his father.

ELXA
(gently)
Marc.

MARC
It's one vote.

ELXA
I know.

MARC
There's still thirty hours of debate, a final passage vote, and then it goes back to the House.

ELXA
I know, baby. Final passage Tuesday. Patti thinks sixty-two.

MARC
Sixty-two?

PATTI
(lifting her face; tears, mascara, total dignity)
Two more called in the last four minutes. Everybody wants to be on a winning team.

Marc finally stands. He walks to the desk. Picks up a pen. Takes Emma's report card out of its plastic sleeve and, under "National Debt: Incomplete," writes in small letters:

INSERT — "In progress. 60–40. — M.B."

ELXA
She's going to be furious you wrote on it.

MARC
She'll grade me down.

(beat)
Get me Senator Murkowski. And then Leader Thune. And then Congresswoman Pruitt. Tell her I want her guardrails in the House version.

DANTE
She's still a no.

MARC
Everybody's a no until they're in the room.

Roy Chapman

Son. That's how you fix an engine.

Tyler

Under it, Pop.

Amond

I DIDN'T EVEN VOTE AND MY HANDS ARE SHAKING

Marc

Lyric's going to be so upset you just sat there.

Amond

She already texted me "that's so dumb" with 6 crying emojis.

Emma

DID YOU WRITE ON MY REPORT CARD

Marc

Maybe

Emma

That's a historical document Dad

Marc

It is now.

THE NEWS — THE REACTION — MONTAGE

SUPER: THURSDAY, JANUARY 22 — 11:24 AM TO 7:00 PM EST

ASSOCIATED PRESS — 11:25 AM EST

Senate advances Bullock's Sovereign Fund, 60–40, as Murkowski casts deciding vote; 8 Republicans join Democrats

Final passage expected Tuesday after the President's concessions on federal land and a dividend for every citizen

THE NEW YORK TIMES

'Not One Acre': How Bullock Rewrote His Biggest Idea to Win the Senate

A Visit to the Republican Lunch, a Dividend From Alaska and a Promise Not to Change the Rules Win 60 Votes

POLITICO

Winners and Losers: The Sovereign Fund Vote

WINNERS: Tyler Chapman, Julian Park, the filibuster. LOSERS: Anyone who said he'd change the rules.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

A Fund Gets a Republican Floor

Lease-Only Lands and a Debt Floor Make the Bullock Fund Better. The Dividend Makes It Permanent, for Better or Worse

FOX NEWS

8 Republicans Cross Over on Bullock Fund; Freedom Caucus Vows Fight in House Conference

Rep. Pruitt: 'Sixty Senators Just Bought the Country a Lottery Ticket'

ANCHORAGE DAILY NEWS

Murkowski Casts 60th Vote on National 'Permanent Fund,' Wins Alaska Native Seat on Its Board

'Alaska Has Done This for Forty Years. Now the Country Can Too.'

NBC NEWS

The 60th Vote: How the Senate's Oldest Rule Survived Its Youngest President

Senate Majority Leader Schumer, on the floor, calls it a "historic bipartisan step." Leader Thune, who voted no himself, tells reporters the President "earned" the eight Republican votes "the old-fashioned way," and that he still has concerns about the fund, but that he'll allow final passage on schedule. Speaker Jeffries says the House will take up the Senate version as soon as it passes.

On Truth Social, the former President posts that he would have gotten "seventy votes," and that the dividend was "my idea, a long time ago." Nobody can find where he said it. Nobody really tries.

Twitter · @GraceBullock

60. No rule changes. Just a President who went to lunch. I was wrong on Tuesday morning and I'm thrilled. Don't tell him I said that. (He's reading this. Hi.)

1.1M Retweets · 7.9M Likes

Twitter · @POTUS

Thank you to the 60 senators, from both parties, who voted to move the American Sovereign Fund forward today. Not one acre sold. A dividend for every citizen. A debt that finally has an end date. And to Senator Murkowski: we put it in writing.

1.4M Retweets · 8.8M Likes

Twitter · @RepJolenePruitt

I'm still a NO. But the White House is putting my inspector general language in the House version. If you're going to build a piggy bank, at least put a lock on it.

77K Retweets · 402K Likes

Twitter · @RepOkoroBanks

The Sovereign Fund now has a dividend for every family in Macomb County. That's why I'm a YES. Not because anyone asked me to be.

12K Retweets · 88K Likes

TikTok · @gen.z.civics

explaining the cloture vote using only Kang references: thread 1/12

14.3M views

Reddit · r/politics

"Murkowski casts 60th vote; Senate invokes cloture on Sovereign Fund, 60–40"

128K upvotes · Top comment: "He didn't nuke the filibuster. He made the filibuster work. I didn't know that was possible." · Reply: "His grandmother-in-law watched C-SPAN for 14 hours. That's the real MVP."

PUNCHBOWL NEWS — 6:12 PM EST

Jeffries: President Accepts Invitation to Deliver First State of the Union to a Joint Session on Tuesday, Feb. 24

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — ODESSA'S BEDROOM — ATLANTA — DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, JANUARY 22 — 11:31 AM EST

C-SPAN still on. Odessa (97) in bed. CORNELIUS SMILLEY (67) sits in the chair beside her, his reading glasses on his forehead, holding her hand. On the wall across from the bed, a framed photograph newly rehung: a jowly, white-haired man in a 1960s suit. Senator Everett Dirksen of Illinois.

Cornelius looks at the photograph. Then at his mother.

CORNELIUS
You told him about Dirksen.

ODESSA
I told him about your father.

CORNELIUS
Daddy would have liked him, Mama.

ODESSA
Your father would have loved him. He was always partial to men who sat at the other fellow's table.

(beat)
You used to be one of those, Cornelius.

Cornelius doesn't answer. He looks at the TV, where the President, at a podium in the Rose Garden in an overcoat, is thanking eight Republican senators by name.

CORNELIUS
(quietly)
I'm trying to be one again.

ODESSA
I know you are, baby.

She pats his hand. Turns back to the television. Turns up the volume.

ODESSA
Now hush. Final passage is Tuesday, and I want to hear who's going to be a problem.

INT. WHITE HOUSE — RESIDENCE — THE TREATY ROOM — NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, JANUARY 22 — 11:52 PM EST

The legal pad from Tuesday morning, still on the Grant table. Bowling ball gone. "57" still circled three times.

Marc sits down. Picks up the pen. Under "57," he writes a "60." Then he crosses out the whole page and starts a new one.

INSERT — the new page, top line, his handwriting: "THE HOUSE: 238–197. NOVEMBER 3. 285 DAYS."

He looks at it a long time. Then, beneath it, he writes one more line.

INSERT — "Year Two."

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER 13

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 13

Timeline: Cold open Tue Jan 20, 2026, 5:47 AM EST (Treaty Room) · Meet the Press Sun Jan 18, 9:00 AM EST · Roosevelt Room Tue Jan 20, 8:02 AM · Dem caucus lunch 12:47 PM · GOP lunch, S-207, 1:32–1:47 PM · Pruitt 1:58 PM · Okoro-Banks 2:06 PM · Grace's briefing 3:31 PM · World News Tonight special 6:30 PM · Murkowski call 9:41 PM · Odessa call 11:14 PM · Oscar nominations Thu Jan 22, 5:30 AM PST · **Cloture invoked 60–40 at 11:24 AM EST Thu Jan 22, 2026** · Treaty Room 11:52 PM.

Ages (Jan 18–22, 2026): Marc 34 (turned 34 Mon Jan 5, 2026) · Esther 33 · Emma & Victoria 13 (8th grade, Sidwell) · Lyric 11 (6th grade, Sidwell) · **Amond 33** (34 on Tue Feb 10) · Harmony 33 · Elxa 35 · Grace 31 · Tayia 33 (34 on Tue Feb 3) · Tyler 34 · Arianna 33 · Tyrese 34 · Dante 44 · Patti 61 (62 on Mon Feb 2) · Natasha 54 · Robert 56 · Victor 79 · Joan 77 · **Odessa 97** · Cornelius 67 · Lorraine 64 · Neil 41 · Simone 38 · Julian Park 38 · Naledi 37 · Gloria Baker 59 · Roy Chapman 68 · Mae Chapman 66 · Agent Okonjo 50 · Mrs. Ernestine Powell 80.

New fictional characters: Rep. Jolene Pruitt (R-TX-26), b. Mar 3, 1984 (41), freshman, Freedom Caucus, former Dallas County prosecutor; the President's sharpest critic (not nerfed), now writing the fund's inspector-general guardrails while still voting no. **Rep. Danielle Okoro-Banks** (D-MI-10), b. Jun 6, 1989 (36), freshman, former auto-plant engineer, flipped a Republican-held Macomb County seat; asked the President to stay out of her district; Amond's UAW shift in Warren set for May 2026.

Real people (ages): Schumer 75 · Thune 65 · Jeffries 55 · Murkowski 68 · Trump 79 · Welker 49 · Bartiromo 58 · Stephanopoulos 64 · Robin Roberts 65 · Jonathan Karl 57 · Muir 52 · Tapper 56 · Enten 37 · Baier 55 · Maddow 52 · Zelenskyy 47. Real people's positions are paraphrased, not quoted, except for one-word Senate votes read by the clerk.

Year One record (canon): Stock Trading Ban Act signed Wed Mar 12, 2025 (House 402–27, Senate 81–18), the first law. **American Families Reconciliation Act**: House Jul 23 (221–214), Senate Thu Aug 7 (50–50, VP Baker's first tie-breaking vote), House re-passes Aug 12 (224–211), signed Thu Aug 14, 2025 (Social Security's 90th anniversary). AmeriCare phase one live Jan 1, 2026 (children and adults 60+; universal by 2028). Universal pre-K money; tuition-free public college for families under $150K; childcare capped at 7% of income; zero federal income tax on the first $50K (tax year 2026). NDAA with the Superpower Act signed Dec 18, 2025. Stopgap funding through Fri Jan 30, 2026 (passed Sep 30, 64–36). 61 laws, 0 vetoes.

American Sovereign Fund Act (H.R. 4410): passed the House Nov 20, 2025 (229–206). Senate changes: **lease-only (no federal land ever sold; state attorneys general can sue to stop a sale) · the American Dividend: 25% of annual earnings to every citizen, set in statute** · a 50% debt-reduction floor · an Alaska Native advisory seat on the board · Pruitt's inspector-general language going into the House version. Debt payoff timeline goes from 28 years to 34. **Cloture invoked 60–40 Thu Jan 22, 2026; 8 Republicans, Murkowski the 60th.** Final passage expected Tue Jan 27 (whip estimate 62). No filibuster change: Marc's line, "If I can't get sixty, it isn't ready."

The Year One dashboard (Jan 2026): CPI 2.3% (Dec, the lowest since early 2021) · unemployment 3.8% · gas $2.78 · 30-year mortgage 5.7% · uninsured 6.1% · consumer sentiment 86.4 · murder rate down 19% · housing starts 1.71M · AmeriCare enrollment 6.4M in 19 days · immigration backlog 2.9M (from 3.7M) · 1.1M lead lines replaced (Flint finished, Nov 2025) · deficit down $300B · **national debt $37.1T (up; "Incomplete")** · Gallup 59% · generic ballot D+5 · Congress approval 31%.

World: Gaza ceasefire collapses Mar 18, 2025, restored Jun 3, last living hostages home Oct 13 · Ukraine ceasefire along the line of contact, Fri Aug 29, 2025 (Geneva), not a peace deal; final-status talks ongoing; Putin still in power · China: "still being weird" (Emma's grade: C-plus) · Pope Francis dies Apr 21, 2025; Pope Leo XIV elected May 8 · VA and NJ governorships stay Democratic, Nov 4, 2025.

Courts (not nerfed): 31 states have sued over the immigration and energy orders; the Supreme Court hears Texas's challenge to EO 14149 in March 2026.

Donohue and the MCU: Kang reveal May 1, 2025 (canon) · "Secret Wars" opens Nov 7, 2025, $1.19B worldwide opening weekend · **Tyrese Avery nominated for Best Actor (98th Academy Awards) for Kang in "Avengers: Secret Wars,"** Thu Jan 22, 2026, the first MCU performance nominated for lead actor · Donohue earns 9 nominations · Marc's stake remains in a blind trust.

Family notes: Emma's report card is now on the Resolute Desk (Healthcare B+, Inflation A, Debt Incomplete → "In progress. 60–40," World Peace C+, Bowling A++) · Victoria's bowling-diplomacy idea is live · Josiah Smilley kept a photo of Sen. Everett Dirksen; Odessa had Cornelius rehang it at Christmas 2025 · Odessa watched 14 hours of C-SPAN.

Looming events: Sovereign Fund final passage (Tue Jan 27) and the House conference · government funding deadline (Fri Jan 30) · **first State of the Union, Tue Feb 24, 2026** · the Supreme Court argument

on EO 14149 (March) · the 98th Oscars · Fed Chair Powell's term ends (May 2026) · Amond's UAW shift (May) · the World Cup in the U.S., Canada and Mexico (from Thu Jun 11) · the USMCA joint review (July) · America's 250th (Sat Jul 4) · **midterms, Tue Nov 3, 2026: the House is 238–197 and history says the President's party loses about two dozen seats.**